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THE WORLD THAT CAME IN FROM THE COLD

Not long before the incidents I've just been writing about, I made a point of going to Africa and testing my ground. It was early days for WikiLeaks and I felt I had to travel in order to broaden, if you like, the mind of the project. I knew that the World Social Forum would be happening in Nairobi in January 2007, and a Melbourne friend, Matt Smith, was willing to finance some of the journey and come with me. The forum sprang up as an alternative to the World Economic Forum. As it was happening in Kenya, I knew it would attract many NGOs and connected participants, which made it the ideal place to give the first full-blown talk about WikiLeaks. I hoped at the time that it would attract volunteers and contacts. We had published a few of our early things, but the big initial leaks – Guantánamo and Fallujah – were to come. I'm sure I felt that opening my stall in Africa would set the tone for us, making it plain from the start that we were a global organisation, not a Western one, with eyes everywhere.

I immediately felt a connection with Africa. The air was different, and during the great period of labour to set things up, I needed a change of atmosphere, as well as the tonic sense of expansiveness that seemed to travel on the wind. Isak Dinesen caught the perfect breeze I'm talking about in *Out of Africa*. 'In the middle of the day the air was alive over the land,' she writes, 'like a flame burning; it scintillated, waved and shone like running water, mirrored and doubled all objects . . . Up in this high air you breathed easily, drawing a vital assurance and lightness of heart. In the highlands you woke up in the morning and thought: Here I am, where I ought to be.'

After buying our $50 visas, Matt and I drove in from the airport and watched the giraffes loping in the distance. They say human beings initially came out of the Rift Valley in Kenya, and so, at some level, coming to Kenya is always a returning to Kenya: you are coming back to what your biology expects, to a certain right degree of light and humidity and